ALEX OKUN

FACILITATOR FIELD GUIDE

A retrospective where people tell you what they really think

A practical guide to one honest team conversation.

THE APPROACH

Alex Okun

Connect with Alex on LinkedIn

A retrospective format shared by Alex, with practical prompts and follow-up tools to help teams put it into practice.

BEFORE YOU START

If you are not genuinely curious about what your team thinks, or are not prepared to hear views you disagree with, do not use this approach in this way. Learn to stay still.

ORIGINAL APPROACH Alex Okun

ADDITIONS Practical prompts and tools

01 / BEFORE THE MEETING

Prepare the conversation

Look back at a project, or look ahead to a deadline, a new semester or a busy period. The question changes; the need to listen does not.

Choose one critical question

Decide what you genuinely want to learn. Five broad questions often give you five shallow answers. Give one important question enough room.

Check your own readiness

Ask yourself what might be hard to hear, whether you can avoid defending past decisions, and what you can realistically act on.

Choose the right facilitator

If people may struggle to speak openly in front of their manager, a neutral facilitator could make the conversation easier.

Set clear expectations

Share the purpose and the question ahead of time. Explain what you will do with the feedback. Do not promise a change you cannot make.

Protect the room

Do not record or transcribe unless it is critical for accessibility. If notes are needed, explain what is captured and who can see it.

INVITATION YOU CAN ADAPT

“I’d like to understand how you feel about [topic]. We’ll focus on [question]. I’m here to listen, including to views I may not agree with. I’ll come back to you about what I heard and what we can do.”

02 / CHOOSE THE QUESTION

One question. Real answers.

Choose one main question from these suggested examples, then ask short follow-up questions only when they help you understand.

LOOKING BACK

What made this piece of work harder than it needed to be?
If we started again tomorrow, what would you change?
What helped us do good work, and what should we protect?

LOOKING AHEAD

What worries you most about the next few months?
What could stop us doing good work?
What do we need to sort out before the next phase?

HOW THE TEAM IS DOING

What is getting in the way of your best work?
What are we not talking about that we should be?
What do you need from the team or its leaders?

These are suggested adaptations, not a script from Alex. Use the one that fits your purpose.

03 / FACILITATE

Hear each person. Protect every round.

Use a roundtable with a speaking order shared in advance. Rotate the order between meetings. For more than five people, Alex recommends booking 90 minutes.

01 **OPEN**

Restate the question and the rules. Take turns. No interruptions or replies during another person's turn. The manager listens and takes notes.

02 **WINS: DO NOT SKIP**

Go round the table: "In the last X months, what went well in your work?" Give each person time to recognise their achievements.

03 **ONE CRITICAL QUESTION**

Each person answers in turn. Before moving on, always ask: "Anything else to add?" The manager asks only for clarification or elaboration.

04 **FURTHER ROUNDS**

Keep the same roundtable order and question. Invite additions and ideas for addressing concerns. People may pass in these later rounds.

05 **APPRECIATION: DO NOT SKIP**

Each person says what was valuable in this meeting, then tells the next person what they appreciated about working with them. The last person thanks the first.

PROTECT THE CLOSE

Reserve time for appreciation. Summarise and propose next steps after the meeting, once you have reflected.

04 / HOLD THE ROUNDTABLE

Stay still.
Let them finish.

The manager does not answer each contribution. Ask only when clarification or elaboration is needed to understand what the person means.

Someone criticises your decision

Listen without defending, correcting or explaining your intent. If you need more detail, ask: "Can you tell me more about that?" If you understand, let them continue.

Someone interrupts or starts a debate

Protect the speaking order: "Please let them finish. You can pick this up when it is your turn." Do not open the floor for replies or competing accounts.

Someone pauses or seems finished

Leave room for silence. Before moving to the next person, always ask: "Is there anything else you would like to add?" Do not answer the main question for them.

A contribution needs more detail

Ask a short question to understand: "Can you give me an example?" or "What did that mean for your work?" Then return the space to the speaker. Do not use questions to challenge their view.

Someone wants an immediate response

Do not turn their turn into a discussion with the manager. Hear the contribution and note it for reflection. Proposed next steps belong in the written follow-up, not an immediate verdict.

THE MANAGER LISTENS THROUGHOUT

Wins, the main question and appreciation are all part of the format. Keep the roundtable intact and protect people from interruption in every round.

05 / AFTER THE MEETING

Reflect first. Then write back.

Alex usually takes almost 48 hours to reflect on the discussion, prepare a summary and propose next steps. The summary does not happen during the meeting.

Give the discussion time

Review your notes and consider the different views before drawing conclusions. Keep concerns visible, including those you disagree with. Do not turn a tentative comment into a team consensus.

Send a summary and proposed next steps

Tell the team what you heard, what you propose doing, what needs more thought and what is outside your control. Keep proposals distinct from decisions already made.

Give the team permission to correct you

Explicitly invite people to call out anything you have paraphrased too much or misrepresented. Correct the record when your wording changes what they meant.

A LINE YOU CAN USE

"This is my summary of what I heard, with proposed next steps. Please call me out if I have paraphrased too much, missed something or misrepresented what you meant."

Keep the follow-up visible

Once next steps are agreed, give actions a named owner and an update date. Report back on progress and carry unresolved issues into the next checkpoint.

THE APPROACH: ALEX OKUN

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This guide is based on Alex’s retrospective format. Example prompts and follow-up tools are suggested additions to support facilitators.